Uncle Tom’s Cabin

Harriet Beecher Stowe · 1852 · selected passages

Source: Harriet Beecher Stowe, Uncle Tom's Cabin (1852), text via Project Gutenberg (#203). Public domain.

Harriet Beecher Stowe wrote Uncle Tom’s Cabin in serial form in 1851–52 as a moral indictment of slavery, motivated specifically by the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850. The novel sold 300,000 copies in its first year and became the best-selling American novel of the 19th century. Apocryphal or not, Lincoln’s reported greeting to Stowe — ‘so this is the little woman who made this great war’ — captures how widely the book was read on both sides of the sectional divide.

Connect: The ‘peculiar institution’ you’re reading about now is what the Wilmot Proviso (Class 17) tried to keep OUT of new territories. Why did white Southern leaders defend it as a ‘positive good’ by the 1830s?

Key Passages

Eliza crossing the ice (Chapter VII)

The huge green fragment of ice on which she alighted pitched and creaked as her weight came on it, but she staid there not a moment. With wild cries and desperate energy she leaped to another and still another cake; stumbling —leaping—slipping—springing upwards again! Her shoes are gone—her stockings cut from her feet—while blood marked every step

Tom’s death scene (Chapter XLI)

“Who,—who,—who shall separate us from the love of Christ?” he said, in a voice that contended with mortal weakness; and, with a smile, he fell asleep.

Why she wrote it (Concluding Remarks)

since the legislative act of 1850, when she heard, with perfect surprise and consternation, Christian and humane people actually recommending the remanding escaped fugitives into slavery, as a duty binding on good citizens, —when she heard, on all hands, from kind, compassionate and estimable people, in the free states of the North, deliberations and discussions as to what Christian duty could be on this head,—she could only think, These men and Christians cannot know what slavery is; if they did, such a question could never be open for discussion.

HIPP Analysis

Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Historical Situation *What was happening when this was written?*	The Compromise of 1850 included a stronger Fugitive Slave Act that required Northerners to help capture people escaping slavery.
Intended Audience *Who was the source written for?*	Northern white middle-class readers, especially women and Christian families, who first read it in serial form in the antislavery newspaper The National Era.

HIPP Element	Your Analysis
Point of View *Whose perspective? Whose is missing?*	Harriet Beecher Stowe, a white Northern woman from a family of ministers and reformers who opposed slavery on moral and religious grounds.
Purpose *What did the author want to accomplish?*	

Analysis Prompts

1. DBQ Thesis (1 pt): Write a defensible thesis on the role of cultural texts (novels, songs, sermons) in deepening the sectional crisis of the 1850s.
2. Why was the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850 specifically the trigger for Stowe?
3. How might a Southern reader and a Northern reader have responded to the same passage?

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> Stowe's bestselling antislavery novel made the human cost of slavery vivid to millions of Northern readers. In this famous scene, the enslaved mother Eliza flees across the ice-choked Ohio River to save her child from being sold.

Eliza crossing the ice (Chapter VII)

A thousand lives seemed to be concentrated in that one moment to Eliza. Her room opened by a side door to the river. She caught her child, and sprang down the steps towards it. The trader caught a full glimpse of her just as she was disappearing down the bank; and throwing himself from his horse, and calling loudly on Sam and Andy, he was after her like a hound after a deer. In that dizzy moment her feet to her scarce seemed to touch the ground, and a moment brought her to the water’s edge. Right on behind they came; and, nerved with strength such as God gives only to the desperate, with one wild cry and flying leap, she vaulted sheer over the turbid current by the shore, on to the raft of ice beyond. It was a desperate leap—impossible to anything but madness and despair; and Haley, Sam, and Andy, instinctively cried out, and lifted up their hands, as she did it. The huge green fragment of ice on which she alighted pitched and creaked as her weight came on it, but she staid there not a moment. With wild cries and desperate energy she leaped to another and still another cake; stumbling—leaping—slipping—springing upwards again! Her shoes are gone—her stockings cut from her feet—while blood marked every step; but she saw nothing, felt nothing, till dimly, as in a dream, she saw the Ohio side, and a man helping her up the bank.

[. . .]

Senator and Mrs. Bird on the fugitive law (Chapter IX)

“Now, John, I want to know if you think such a law as that is right and Christian?” “You won’t shoot me, now, Mary, if I say I do!” “I never could have thought it of you, John; you didn’t vote for it?” “Even so, my fair politician.” “You ought to be ashamed, John! Poor, homeless, houseless creatures! It’s a shameful, wicked, abominable law, and I’ll break it, for one, the first time I get a chance; and I hope I shall have a chance, I do! Things have got to a pretty pass, if a woman can’t give a warm supper and a bed to poor, starving creatures, just because they are slaves, and have been abused and oppressed all their lives, poor things!” “But, Mary, just listen to me. Your feelings are all quite right, dear, and interesting, and I love you for them; but, then, dear, we mustn’t suffer our feelings to run away with our judgment; you must consider it’s a matter of private feeling,—there are great public interests involved,—there is such a state of public agitation rising, that we must put aside our private feelings.” “Now, John, I don’t know anything about politics, but I can read my Bible; and there I see that I must feed the hungry, clothe the naked, and comfort the desolate; and that Bible I mean to follow.”

[. . .]

Tom’s death scene (Chapter XLI)

At this moment, the sudden flush of strength which the joy of meeting his young master had infused into the dying man gave way. A sudden sinking fell upon him; he closed his eyes; and that mysterious and sublime change passed over his face, that told the approach of other worlds. He began to draw his breath with long, deep inspirations; and his broad chest rose and fell, heavily. The expression of his face was that of a conqueror. “Who,—who,—who shall separate us from the love of Christ?” he said, in a voice that contended with mortal weakness; and, with a smile, he fell asleep. George sat fixed with solemn awe. It seemed to him that the place was holy; and, as he closed the lifeless eyes, and rose up from the dead, only one thought possessed him,—that expressed by his simple old friend,—“What a thing it is to be a Christian!”

[. . .]

Concluding Remarks (Chapter XLV) — why Stowe wrote the book

For many years of her life, the author avoided all reading upon or allusion to the subject of slavery, considering it as too painful to be inquired into, and one which advancing light and civilization would certainly live down. But, since the legislative act of 1850, when she heard, with perfect surprise and consternation, Christian and humane people actually recommending the remanding escaped fugitives into slavery, as a duty binding on good citizens,—when she heard, on all hands, from kind, compassionate and estimable people, in the free states of the North, deliberations and discussions as to what Christian duty could be on this head,—she could only think, These men and Christians cannot know what slavery is; if they did, such a question could never be open for discussion.

[. . .]

Concluding Remarks — ‘see to it that they feel right’

But, what can any individual do? Of that, every individual can judge. There is one thing that every individual can do,—they can see to it that they feel right. An atmosphere of sympathetic influence encircles every human being; and the man or woman who feels strongly, healthily and justly, on the great interests of humanity, is a constant benefactor to the human race. See, then, to your sympathies in this matter! Are they in harmony with the sympathies of Christ? or are they swayed and perverted by the sophistries of worldly policy?

Words to know

turbid — muddy, churning water

abominable — hateful and morally disgusting

pretty pass — a bad state of affairs

sublime — awe-inspiring and holy

consternation — shocked dismay

remanding — sending back, here returning escaped slaves to their owners

sophistries — clever but false arguments